Turn Down the Static

Who is who

Wren Alvarez, 11. She has one rule about her bedroom door.

Theo Alvarez, 8, her brother. He likes rules, clouds and exact numbers.

Mom and Dad (Dana and Sam). Mom has a new shift. Dad has a lot of cereal.

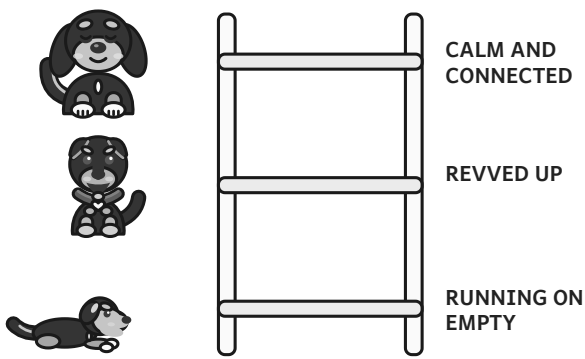
Grandpa Lou, Dad's father. He has a bad knee and opinions about weather.

Tidbit and Sugarfoot, the family dogs. Tidbit zooms. Sugarfoot strolls.

Imani, Mateo and Josie, Wren's friends. Together they are the Four Corners.

Mrs. Okafor and Ms. Park, a teacher who loves weather and a librarian who loves stickers.

Professor Puddles, a raindrop with glasses. He turns up after every chapter.



Turn Down the Static

A story about a group chat, a crowded house and finding your way back to each other

by Christian

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How it was made. The words were drafted with an AI writing tool. The pictures were drawn by code that was written with an AI tool. The story and characters are original to this site.

Made up. Wren, Theo and their family and friends are made up. Nobody in this book is a real person, and none of it is a testimonial.

Not therapy. This is a story. It is general education about feelings and getting along, not a diagnosis or treatment, and it cannot know your family.

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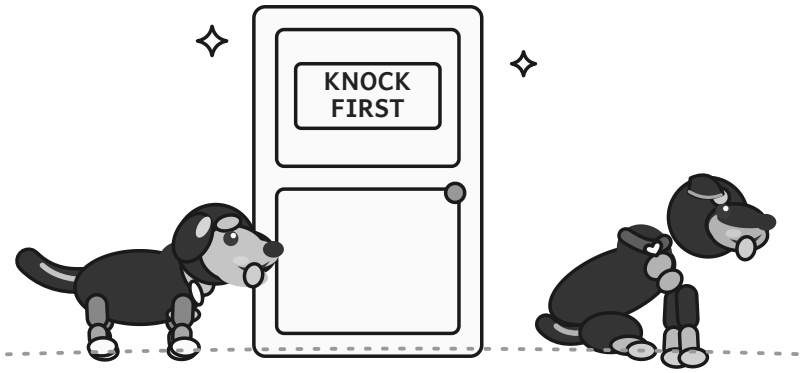
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CHAPTER 1

Half a Room



Wren Alvarez had exactly one rule about her bedroom, and she had written it on the door in glitter pen: KNOCK FIRST.

Her brother Theo never needed the sign. Theo knocked three times, waited, and said "It's Theo" every single time, as if there were a chance it might be somebody else. The dogs could not read, so they ignored the sign and came in anyway. Tidbit zoomed. Sugarfoot strolled. Between the two of them, Wren's rule was mostly a suggestion.

On the last Sunday in September, her dad knocked. Once. Then he opened the door without waiting, which was Clue Number One.

"Family meeting," he said. "Kitchen. Mom made pancakes."

Clue Number Two. Wren put down her sketchbook. In the Alvarez house, pancakes on a Sunday meant one of two things: either something wonderful had happened, or something big was about to.

"Is it a puppy?" she asked.

"We have two dogs."

"Is it a vacation?"

"Kitchen," said Dad.

The kitchen smelled like butter and maple syrup. Mom stood at the stove in her work badge, even though it was Sunday, which was Clue Number Three. Theo was already at the table with his headphones around his neck, lining up his fork, his knife and his napkin so that all three pointed the same way. Tidbit sat under his chair like a small black cannon waiting for a pancake to fall. Sugarfoot lay across the doorway, because that was where she always lay, so that everybody had to step over her and say "Excuse me, Sugarfoot."

"Okay," Mom said, sliding a plate in front of Wren. "Here's the news. Grandpa Lou is coming to live with us."

Wren's fork stopped halfway to her mouth.

"For how long?" asked Theo. He asked it plainly, the way he asked everything. Theo wanted the real answer, and he wanted it in a number.

"For a while," Dad said. "His building is getting new pipes and new floors, and then the landlord is selling it. Three

flights of stairs are a lot for his knee anyway. So he'll stay here until he finds a new place."

"How long is a while?" said Theo.

"We don't know yet. A few months, maybe more."

Theo thought about this. "That is not a number," he said, and he took his headphones off his neck and put them back on, which was how Theo said *I need a minute.*

Wren loved Grandpa Lou. She really did. He told terrible jokes and bad weather forecasts. He could whistle through his fingers. When she was little, he had taught her to skip stones on the lake and to eat watermelon with salt.

So she was surprised by the heat that started in her face and spread to her ears.

"Where is he going to sleep?" she asked.

Mom and Dad looked at each other. It was a quick look, the kind that has a whole conversation inside it.

"Well," Dad said. "He can't do the stairs. And the only bedroom on the first floor is..."

"Mine," said Wren.

"Yours," Mom said gently. "It's just for a little while. And we thought, since Theo's room has plenty of space..."

"No," said Wren.

"Wren."

“I’m not sharing with Theo. Nothing against Theo.” She glanced at him. He was studying the ceiling tiles. “But I’m eleven. I need a door. I have a sign.”

“I know you do,” Mom said. “I know it’s a big change. Nobody’s decided anything about the details yet. We wanted to tell you first and talk it through together.”

That was a nice thing to say. It was a perfectly reasonable thing to say. But Wren’s hands had gone prickly, and her heart was knocking around in her chest like a dog who wants out, and her brain had stopped producing words that were useful.

“Fine,” she said.

It came out flat and fast. She pushed back her chair, and it scraped, and Theo flinched. She stepped over Sugarfoot without saying “Excuse me.” She went upstairs and shut her door, and she did not knock first on the way out, because it was her own door.

She sat on her bed with her back against the wall and looked at the room that was about to stop being hers.

There was a poster of a rainy city. There was a shelf of sketchbooks. There was the glow-in-the-dark star she had stuck on the ceiling when she was six, right over the pillow, a little crooked. Someone else was going to sleep under that star.

A whine at the door. Then a bump. Tidbit pushed through the gap with her nose and jumped on the bed, circled three

times and flopped across her feet.

"Don't," Wren told her. "I'm mad."

Tidbit licked her ankle. A minute later, Sugarfoot arrived at her own speed, put her chin on the edge of the mattress and gazed at Wren with her big brown eyes and her long drooping ears.

"I'm not mad at you," Wren said. "I'm not even mad at Grandpa."

She wasn't sure who she was mad at. That was part of the problem. Her mad had no address.

There was a knock. Three knocks, a pause.

"It's Theo."

Wren let out a breath. "Come in."

He opened the door and stayed in the doorway, one foot on the hall carpet and one on her floor. He had his headphones around his neck again. In his hand was a piece of paper.

"I made you something," he said. "You looked like Grumble."

"Like who?"

"Grumble. From the Static." He held out the paper. It was a drawing, done in careful gray pencil: a cloud with a frown and two angry eyebrows and little zigzags around it. Underneath, in his small square handwriting, he had

written: GRUMBLE. WHAT HE WANTS: TO BE HEARD. WHAT HELPS: A MINUTE.

Wren looked at it for a long time. Theo's whole shelf was full of the Frequency Buddies, the cartoon he watched every day at exactly four-thirty. Tidbit and Sugarfoot were named after the two pups in it, and so were half the stuffed animals in his bed. The rest were Ollie the owl, Dot the snail, Hopper the frog, Nutmeg the squirrel, Lumi the red panda and Beep the robot, lined up on his shelf by height, with three yellow ducklings at the end because they were the shortest. In the cartoon, the clouds of Static were what floated in when feelings got too loud. There was Grumble, who was gray and grumpy, and Fuzz, who was purple and prickly, and Mumble, who was shy and peach-colored and hid in corners, and Drift, who was green and wandered off whenever things got hard.

"I don't look like that," Wren said.

Theo tilted his head. "Your eyebrows are in the same position."

She felt her mouth twitch. It was impossible to stay completely angry at someone who delivered news like a weather reporter.

"Is this what you do when you get loud inside?" she asked. "Draw it?"

"Sometimes. Or count the ceiling tiles." He considered. "Mom says it is okay to need a minute. She says I just have to tell people I'm taking it."

"That's a good rule."

"I know," Theo said. "I wrote it on my wall."

Wren laughed, a short surprised laugh, and some of the heat went out of her ears. She patted the bed. Theo came in, step by careful step, and sat at the very edge, as far from Tidbit's tail as possible.

"I don't want to share a room," Wren said.

"I know. Your face said so." He nodded. "I don't know if I want to either. I like my room the way it is. But Grandpa knows all the names of the clouds."

"The real ones?"

"Cumulus. Stratus. Nimbus." Theo smiled, and it was the smile he gave only to facts he was really fond of. "He told me on the phone. He says there are ten kinds."

Downstairs, a pan clattered. Somebody turned off the radio. Through the floor came the low sound of their parents talking, and Wren thought: *they are probably worried about me.* The knot in her chest stayed the same size. It felt a little less lonely, though.

She tacked Theo's drawing to her corkboard. Grumble frowned down at her, gray and ridiculous.

"Okay," she said to the drawing. "You can stay."

She did not say it to her parents. Not yet. She was still too revved up for that, and she knew it, a little. She just did

not yet have a word for what her body was doing, or the first idea what to do about it.

That part would come later. The first thing that came, on the very next day, was a text.

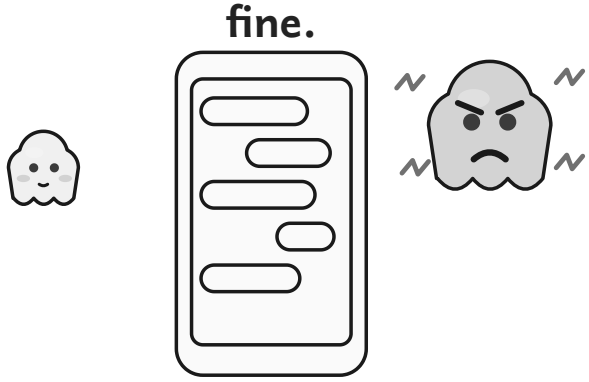


Try this

- Notice your body before you say anything. Are your hands prickly, your face hot, your heart knocking? That is your body telling you it is revved up.
- If you can, say what you are doing: "I need a minute." Theo's rule works for anyone.
- Next time you are mad and don't know at whom, try drawing the mad. What does it look like? What does it want? What helps?

CHAPTER 2

Fine



The text came in at 7:12 on Monday morning, while Wren was standing in the hallway holding a toothbrush.

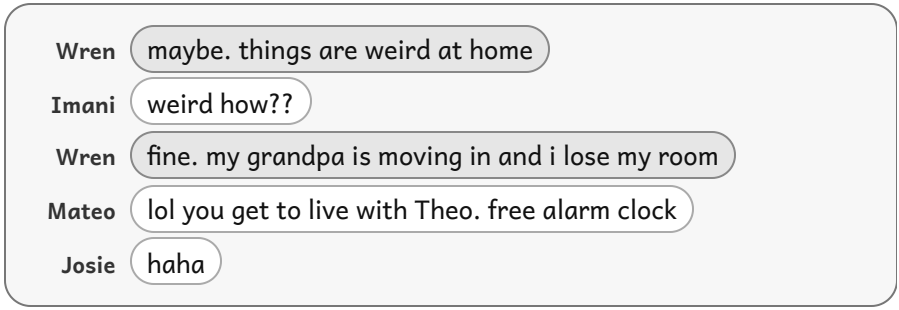
Imani sleepover friday?? my place. nana is making peach cobbler

Josie YES

Mateo obviously. i will bring the good controller

She looked at it for a while. A sleepover at Imani's was one of the best things a person could be invited to. Imani's nana made cobbler with a crust like a cloud, and Imani's dad let them stay up until the second movie ended. Wren would normally have typed three exclamation points before the toothbrush was even in her mouth.

But her chest still felt like a sock drawer somebody had dumped out on the floor. She typed.



Wren stared at the screen.

Free alarm clock.

She knew what Mateo meant. Theo did wake up at 6:00 every morning, exactly, because 6:00 was when he woke up. Everybody in the family knew that. It was kind of a joke, even a fond one.

But it didn't feel like a joke right now. It felt like Mateo was saying that her whole big problem was something to laugh about, and that Theo was something to laugh about, and that was not a thing anyone else got to do. Wren was allowed to be annoyed with Theo. Nobody else was.

Her thumbs went fast.



K.

One letter. It sat there by itself, small and gray and cold. Imani had typed “weird how??” with two question marks, and then, when Wren finally said something, all she wrote back was *k*.

Wren turned the phone face down on the sink. Her heart was banging. She brushed her teeth so hard her gums stung.

• • •

By lunch she had a headache.

The thing about the group chat was that it kept going even when you stopped. All morning, her phone buzzed against her leg in her backpack. Buzz, buzz. She did not look at it. Not looking took more energy than looking would have.

In math, Josie leaned over and whispered, “Are you coming Friday or not?”

“I said maybe.”

“Okay. You don’t have to bite.”

“I didn’t bite,” said Wren, who had bitten.

Josie turned back to her worksheet with her ears a little pink. Wren felt a flash of guilt, then a flash of anger at the guilt, and then, because it was the only thing left to do, she looked out the window and counted the bricks on the building across the parking lot. She didn’t know she was doing it until she reached forty-one. It was the thing Theo did with ceiling tiles.

At lunch, Imani sat down across from her with a tray and a careful face.

"Hi," Imani said.

"Hi."

"Are you mad at me?"

Wren's first thought was *Yes.* Her second thought was *Why?* because she could not have said exactly why. Her third thought was a lot of words, all of them sharp.

"I'm fine," she said.

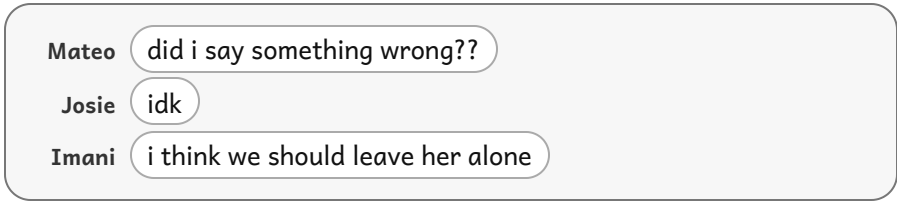
Imani's face did something small and closed up. "Okay," she said. She picked up her sandwich. She put it down again. "You said fine like four times this morning."

"Because I'm fine."

"Okay."

They ate without talking. Mateo came, said "What did I miss?" and got no answer from either of them, and went to sit with the soccer kids. The table felt as wide as a parking lot.

Wren's phone buzzed again. This time she looked.



Leave her alone.

That was it. That was what she'd wanted, right? To be left alone? But reading it hurt like pressing on a bruise. They were talking about her, in a place she could see but not talk back to, as if she were a weather system that had come in over the school.

Without really deciding to, she typed, deleted it, typed again.



Then she muted the chat, pushed back her chair and walked out of the cafeteria, past the kid with the juice box and the teacher with the whistle, down the hall to the bathroom, where she locked herself in a stall and put her forehead against the cool metal door.

Her ears were hot. Her stomach was tight. Her hands were shaking a little. Her thoughts were going so fast they were tripping over each other: *They think I'm a problem. They're laughing at Theo. I lost my room and nobody cares. Imani hates me. Nobody gets it.*

She did not know that every one of those thoughts was a guess. They didn't feel like guesses. They felt like facts. Facts, she'd find out, usually have a bit less shouting in them.

After a while, the bell rang, and the hot feeling drained away and left something worse: a flat, tired, gray feeling, like a battery at one percent. In science she forgot her

notebook. In the hallway she walked into the corner of a locker and didn't even say ow.

By the time she got home, she wasn't revved up anymore. She was running on empty.

• • •

The kitchen smelled like onions. Grandpa Lou's boxes would arrive on Saturday, and until then, the house was in the strange quiet of a place that knows something is coming. Mom was home early, standing at the counter with her laptop open and her badge still on.

"Hi, honey. How was school?"

"Fine."

Mom looked up. She did not say anything. She just looked, the way she did when she was reading a label.

On the fridge, held up by a magnet shaped like a pickle, was Theo's chart. He had made it two years ago, and the family had been using it ever since, with only a little grumbling. It was a ladder, drawn with a ruler. At the top rung, in green marker: CALM AND CONNECTED. In the middle, in orange: REVVED UP. At the bottom, in gray: RUNNING ON EMPTY. Next to each rung was a list of what it felt like, in Theo's neat capitals. REVVED UP: HOT EARS. FAST HEART. TOO MANY WORDS. RUNNING ON EMPTY: HEAVY. FLAT. WANT TO HIDE.

There were four magnets at the side, one for each of them, and a pickle-shaped extra one for company. Mom's

was on the green rung. Dad's, which he'd put there that morning before work, was on the green rung too, with a tiny sticky note: *Big news day, nervous.* Theo's was on orange. His note said: *Too many unknowns.*

Wren's magnet was lying on the counter. She picked it up.

"Where are you?" Mom asked, softly.

"I told you. Fine."

"Fine isn't a rung," Mom said, and for a second Wren almost smiled, because it was true, and because Mom said it so seriously.

She put her magnet on the gray one. Then she didn't wait to be asked anything else. She went upstairs and lay down on the bed that was almost not hers anymore, and Sugarfoot came in at her own pace, climbed up and lay with her warm side against Wren's legs.

Nobody said anything. That was exactly right.

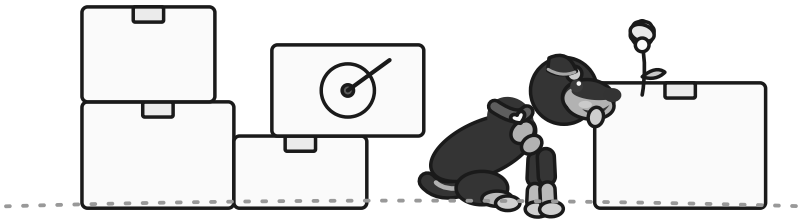


Try this

- Reading a message, you only get the words. You don't get the face or the voice. Before you answer, read it again in a different voice. What if they were tired? Busy? Wearing gloves and typing with one thumb?
- "Fine" can mean fine, or it can mean "I'm not ready to say." If you hear it, you can ask, "Does fine mean fine, or do you need a minute?"
- When you answer a hard message while your heart is racing, you may send a different message than you meant. Wait until your ears cool down.

CHAPTER 3

Boxes



Grandpa Lou arrived on Saturday morning in the back of a rented truck, sitting on a kitchen chair.

"He's not supposed to ride like that," Dad muttered, as the truck pulled into the driveway. But Grandpa Lou climbed down with one hand on the tailgate and one raised in the air, like a king arriving at a very small kingdom, and called out, "Forecast for today! Bright, with a ninety percent chance of boxes!"

Wren was standing on the front steps with her arms folded. She had planned to look neutral. Then he spotted her and his whole face went up like a window shade, and she felt her arms unfold on their own.

"There she is. The weather girl."

"I'm not the weather girl, Grandpa."

"You drew the rain on my fridge calendar for a whole year. I'd call that credentials." He hugged her. He smelled like peppermint and sawdust, which was how he always smelled. "Listen. I know I'm taking your room. If I could have picked any other place on earth to put a bad knee, believe me, I would have."

That was so exactly what Wren had been thinking that she didn't know what to say. "It's okay," she said, which was only a little bit true.

"It's not," said Grandpa Lou, "but it will be."

Then the unloading began, and the house filled up with noise.

There were a lot of boxes. There was a record player in a case and a crate of records. There were three plants that had to ride in the front seat because they got carsick. There was a coffee can of mismatched screws that Grandpa insisted on carrying himself, and a toolbox, and a lamp shaped like a lighthouse, and a wooden barometer that he hung in the hall at once, tapping it with one finger and saying "Hm."

Dad and two neighbors carried the heavy things. Mom stood in the hall with a clipboard. Tidbit ran in circles around everybody's legs, thrilled by the sheer amount of new smells, and Sugarfoot sat on the porch and supervised. Somebody turned on the radio. Somebody else started the drill, because Grandpa's bed had to be put together first,

and the drill went *rrrrRRRRR* through the walls of the whole house.

It was a lot. Wren felt it in her teeth.

And then she noticed that she hadn't seen Theo in a while.

• • •

She found him under the dining room table.

He was sitting with his knees pulled up and his headphones clamped on over his ears, with the big noise-blocking kind that he wore on the bus. His eyes were shut. His lips were moving. Tidbit, who had slipped under there to find him, was lying across his feet and panting in a worried way.

Wren crouched down and lifted the edge of the tablecloth.

"Theo."

Nothing. His lips kept moving. She leaned closer. *Forty-one. Forty-two. Forty-three.* He was counting the slats on the underside of the table.

Her first feeling, honestly, was annoyance. It rose before she could stop it. It was Saturday. Grandpa Lou was here. Everyone was working. And her brother was hiding under a table.

"Of course," she muttered. "Of course it has to be about him."

She did not say it loudly. But Theo had heard something. His eyes opened. He pushed one headphone off his ear.

"I'm taking a minute," he said. His voice was very small and very exact. "It's too loud. There's drilling and a radio and four people talking at once. I can't hear the one thing I'm supposed to be hearing. I told Mom. She said that was okay."

"I didn't say it wasn't okay."

"You said it was about me."

Wren opened her mouth and closed it.

It was true. She had said it. And she had been about to say a second thing, which was *You always do this*, and she was suddenly glad she had not.

"Sorry," she said. "That wasn't fair."

"Okay," said Theo. He put the headphone back.

She stayed crouched there, with the tablecloth hanging over her shoulder and her knee going numb, and she didn't know what to do. If she went away, he would be alone, but she'd guessed that was what he wanted. If she stayed, she might be too much. If she said something, it might be the wrong thing. She felt clumsy, like a person trying to carry a full bowl of soup across a room.

"Do you want me to go?" she asked.

Theo opened his eyes. "I don't know. I'm still counting."

"Okay. I'll stay, but I won't talk."

"That would be good," he said, and closed his eyes again.

So she sat down on the floor, next to the table leg, and did not talk. Tidbit moved over and put her head in Wren's lap. A minute went by. Another. The drill stopped. The radio got turned down. Somebody laughed in the hallway, and it was a normal-sized laugh, and Theo's shoulders came down from around his ears, a little at a time.

A new pair of feet appeared at the edge of the tablecloth. They were wearing slippers shaped like loaves of bread.

"Mind if I join the meeting?" said Grandpa Lou.

"The meeting is under the table," Theo said, without opening his eyes.

"So I see." Grandpa Lou considered the problem. Then, to Wren's surprise, he lowered himself carefully to the floor, with a sound like a slow tire going flat, and crawled in under the tablecloth with them, bad knee and all. He wedged himself between a chair leg and a box of records, and he did not say a single word.

The three of them sat there, breathing.

After a while, Theo pushed both headphones down around his neck.

"Is it over?" he asked.

Wren looked at Grandpa, ready for a joke. But he answered the question exactly as it was asked.

"The drilling is over," he said. "The radio is off. There are still about thirty boxes, and I'm going to be here for a few months. So part of it is over, and part of it isn't."

Theo thought about this. "Thank you," he said. "Most people say yes."

"Most people say yes to make you feel better," said Grandpa Lou. "I'd rather tell you the weather as it is. It's more useful."

Something shifted in Theo's face. It was a small shift, like a curtain moving in a window. "That's what I like about clouds," he said.

"Me too."

Wren looked from one of them to the other, and a funny thing happened inside her. She had thought she would feel left out. Instead she felt a little bit like she was watching two people discover they spoke the same language, which, she realized, they probably did. It was a language where you said exactly what you meant and you told the truth about how much was left to go.

Theo isn't wired wrong, she thought. *He and I are wired differently, and we keep missing each other.*

She wasn't sure that was an original thought. It had a slightly Mom-ish ring. But it felt like hers.

• • •

They carried the boxes in all afternoon. Wren's things went upstairs in a pile of her own boxes, labeled in marker:

BOOKS, SKETCHBOOKS, CLOTHES, STUFF. She was going to be sleeping on the spare bed in Theo's room, the one the cousins used when they visited, under a ceiling with no star on it.

By dinner, Grandpa Lou was settled in her old room. Wren walked past the open door. He'd hung his barometer on her wall right above the glowing star, which was still stuck to the ceiling, since nobody could reach it.

"It's a good star," said Grandpa Lou from the bed, where he was resting his knee on two pillows. "I'll keep an eye on it for you."

"Thanks."

"Wren." He waited until she looked at him. "When I get quiet, it doesn't mean anything is wrong. I just do my thinking in the dark. And when I talk too much, it usually means I'm nervous. I'm going to be nervous for a bit. New house and all."

"You're nervous?"

"Terrified," said Grandpa Lou happily. "Tell your mother I said I'm fine."

"That isn't fine, Grandpa," Wren said. "Fine isn't a rung."

"A what?"

"Never mind. I'll show you the fridge."

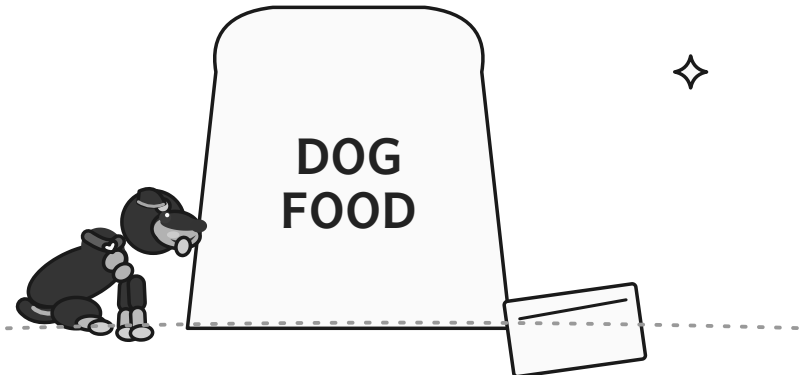


Try this

- Some people need quiet to settle, and some people need company. Neither is a mistake. You can ask: “Do you want room, or do you want me close?”
- If someone is taking a minute, you can sit nearby without talking. Your calm can keep them company.
- When you answer a question, you can say how much is true. “The drilling is over, and thirty boxes are left” is a better answer than a plain yes.

CHAPTER 4

The Permission Slip



On Thursday morning, Wren's science museum permission slip was missing.

It had been in her backpack on Monday. She was almost sure. Then Grandpa Lou's boxes had happened, and Theo's schedule had happened, and the slip had gone wherever things go when you aren't looking at them.

"It's due today," Wren said, tipping her backpack upside down on the kitchen floor. Out fell three pencils, a granola bar with a bite out of it, and a sock that was not hers. "Mrs. Okafor said no slip, no museum."

"Where did you last see it?" said Dad, who was pouring cereal with the dazed look of a man who had been awake since five.

"If I knew that, it wouldn't be lost!"

Dad flinched. Wren felt a prickle of guilt, but she was also panicking, and when she panicked, her volume got ahead of her.

"I'll check the pile," said Dad, and he went to look in the pile.

In the Alvarez house, there was a pile. It lived on the end of the counter and consisted of mail, school notices, a library book that was three weeks late, and a sticky note that said *CALL ABOUT THE THING*. Mom was the person who knew what was in the pile. Mom was the one who sorted it every Sunday night with a cup of tea and a stack of colored paper clips.

But Mom, this week, was not here. She had started a new shift at work, with early mornings and two late nights, and she had left at 6:10 with a travel mug and a kiss on the top of Wren's head.

"I don't see it," Dad called.

"It has a green border! And you have to sign it!"

"Wren." Dad came back, holding the library book. "I'm looking. Take a breath."

She did not take a breath. She felt hot all over. "Mom would know where it is."

"Mom's at work."

"Mom always knows."

It came out sharper than she meant. Dad stopped with his hand on the library book. There was a short, strange silence, the kind where everyone is thinking something and nobody wants to be the first.

"You're right," Dad said slowly. "She does."

He didn't say it angrily. He said it like a man finding something under the couch he had not known was there.

At that moment, Tidbit, who had been investigating the open pantry, backed out with a bag of dog food in her teeth and dragged it across the kitchen. Something fluttered out from beneath it. A square of paper with a green border.

"Oh," said Wren.

"Oh," said Dad.

Theo, who had been sitting very still at the table with his toast cut into four equal triangles, said calmly: "The dog gets fed at 5:30. Mom feeds her at 5:30. This week Mom wasn't here at 5:30. The bag moved."

They both stared at him.

"I'm just saying how the slip got there," said Theo.

Dad sat down at the table and put his head in his hands. For a moment, Wren thought he was upset. Then she realized his shoulders were shaking. He was laughing.

"It was under the dog food," he said. "The whole time. The dog food was on it."

"I'm still late," said Wren. But the thing in her chest let go a little, and she started laughing too, and then Theo, who did not always laugh when other people did but did sometimes laugh at surprising things, said "The bag moved," once more, solemnly, and that was it. All three of them were gone.

Dad signed the slip. Wren made the bus by forty seconds.

• • •

That evening, Grandpa Lou called a meeting.

"I've been in this house for five days," he announced, standing at the head of the kitchen table with his reading glasses on his forehead and a yellow legal pad in his hand. "And I've noticed something. Your mother runs this household like an air traffic controller. And I've never seen her sit down."

"That's not true," said Dad. "She sits sometimes."

"Name one."

Dad opened his mouth, closed it, and looked at the ceiling.

"Exactly," said Grandpa Lou. He clicked a pen. "Let's make a list. Everything that has to happen in a week, in this house, to keep everybody alive and fed and in clean socks. I'll write. You shout."

It started slowly. "Dishes," said Wren. "Trash." "Dog food," said Theo. "Laundry." "Groceries." "Lunches."

Grandpa Lou wrote it all down. Then he looked up. "That's the doing. What about the other part?"

"What other part?"

"The part before the doing. Somebody has to notice that the milk is almost out. Somebody has to remember that Theo's bus changes on Fridays. Somebody has to know that the dentist appointment is on the fourteenth and the permission slip is due on Thursday and that Theo's shoes are too small."

Nobody said anything.

"Who knows all that?" said Grandpa Lou, gently.

"Mom," said Wren.

"Mom," said Dad, a little quietly.

"Mom," Theo agreed. "And she writes it on the pile."

"That," said Grandpa Lou, writing at the top of a new page in big letters, *NOTICING*, *REMEMBERING*, *PLANNING*, "is also work. It's the invisible kind. You can't see it, but when it isn't done, everything falls over, and then a slip of paper is lost under the dog food."

Wren looked at the list. She had never once thought of *remembering* as a job. It had always just happened, as if it were weather.

"It's a lot," she said.

"It's a lot," Grandpa Lou agreed. "And that's no complaint about anybody. Your mother's way of doing it works fine.

She has been carrying the whole bag because nobody mentioned it was heavy. So let's look at the whole bag together and decide who carries what."

"A job should have one owner," said Theo.

They all turned.

"The Frequency Buddies had this problem," Theo said. He sat up straighter. "In the episode with the basket. Everybody thought somebody else was bringing the apples, so nobody did. Then Professor Puddles said, 'A job that belongs to everyone belongs to no one.' So they gave each friend one job."

"That's very wise," said Grandpa Lou. "Who's Professor Puddles?"

"He's a raindrop with glasses."

"Then he's my kind of man."

So they did it. It took an hour. Every job on the list got one owner and one backup, written in two columns: *Who does it* and *Who steps in.* Wren took lunches (hers and Theo's) and the dishes on weeknights. Dad took the laundry and the Tuesday dinner. Grandpa Lou took the plants, the fix-it list, and Wednesday dinner, which he announced would be "mostly soup." Theo, who had gone very quiet and then very focused, said he wanted to feed the dogs.

"At 5:30," said Wren, smiling.

"At exactly 5:30," said Theo. "Every day. And I will put a card on the bag so it doesn't move."

That was the first time Wren had thought: *fair doesn't mean everybody does the same thing.* Theo's job had clear steps and a fixed time, which he liked. Dad's job was big and boring, which Dad claimed to like. Wren's job needed a little planning, and she found she didn't mind. A fair share was one that actually fit the person who had to carry it.

And Mom's jobs? Grandpa Lou drew a thick line across the bottom of the page. "Your mother's list," he said, "is now whatever's left after we do all this. And we are going to check every Sunday that it is shorter than it was."

"What about the pile?" said Dad.

"I'll take the pile," said Wren, surprising herself. "Just the sorting. And the dates. I'll put them on the whiteboard."

Dad looked at her for a long moment. Then he reached across the table and squeezed her shoulder. "Thank you," he said, and she could tell he meant it, and he also meant *I'm sorry I didn't see it either.*

When Mom came home at ten that night, tired and carrying a bag of takeout noodles, she found a whiteboard on the fridge with every job on it and a pickle-shaped magnet holding up a note. The note was in Theo's handwriting. It said:

DEAR MOM. YOU ARE NOT THE ONLY ONE WHO REMEMBERS NOW. LOVE, THEO. P.S. THE DOG FOOD IS FINE.

Mom read it twice. Then she sat down at the kitchen table, put her face in her hands, and stayed there.

Wren's stomach did a flip, and she took a step forward. But Dad was already pulling out the chair next to her. He sat close, one hand on her back, and said nothing. Mom's shoulders went up and down. After a minute she looked up, and she was laughing and crying at the same time.

"I did not know," she said, "how tired I was."

"We know," said Grandpa Lou, from the doorway, with a pot of soup. "That's why there's soup."

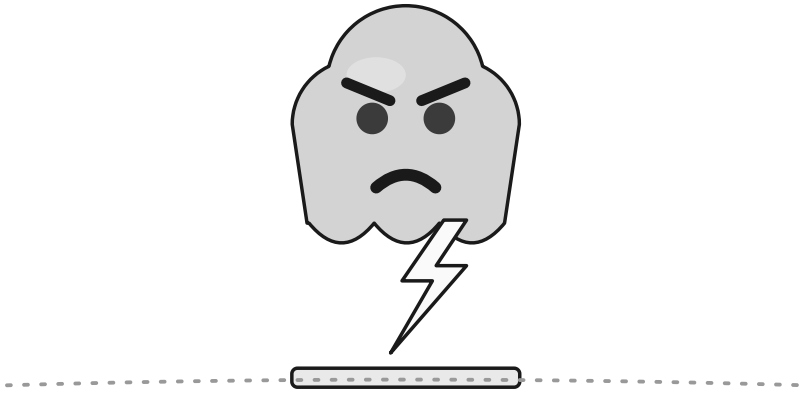


Try this

- Jobs have two parts: the doing, and the noticing, remembering and planning. Write both on your list. The second part is easy to miss because nobody sees it.
- Give each job one owner and one backup. "Everybody's job" often means nobody's.
- A fair share fits the person who has to carry it. If one person likes a clear time and steps, and another likes a big job to chew on, they can both be fair.

CHAPTER 5

The Project



Mrs. Okafor loved weather almost as much as Grandpa Lou did, which was unfortunate for Wren, because the next project was about it.

"Groups of four," Mrs. Okafor said on Friday morning, tapping the board. "You will build a model of a weather system, make a poster that explains it, and give a five-minute talk. Due next Friday. Choose your groups. Quickly."

Wren's stomach dropped. She hadn't really talked to the Four Corners since Monday. Imani had waved on Tuesday, a small unsure wave. Josie had saved her a seat on Wednesday and Wren had pretended not to see. Mateo had sent three memes, which she'd left on read. The group chat sat muted on her phone like a sleeping animal.

Now it came across the room at her, in the form of three people with their chairs already moving.

"Hi," said Imani, sliding her desk next to Wren's. "We saved you a place."

"Okay," said Wren.

"Cool," said Mateo, a little too loudly. "So. Weather."

He took out a notebook. Mateo always had a notebook. He talked fast when he was nervous, and he was visibly nervous now, with his knee bouncing under the desk.

"So here's my idea," he said, flipping pages. "We do a thunderstorm. I'll build the model, because I have the clay and my dad has a hot glue gun. Imani, you're good at drawing, so you do the poster. Josie, you write the talk, because you're good at words. And Wren, you can, um..."

He looked at his notebook.

"You can do the labels."

"The labels," said Wren.

"The little cloud labels. Cumulus, nimbus, that stuff. It's easy." He flipped the page. "Then we practice Wednesday, and I'll put it all on one slide. Okay? Good. Everybody got their job?"

The ordinary part of Wren understood. Mateo was trying to be organized. He wanted to get it done. He was probably worried they'd run out of time.

But there was another part, and that part was already past the ordinary part and out the door, because it had heard only this: *You get the little cloud labels. Everyone else gets a real job. You don't get a vote.*

"You didn't ask me," she said.

"What?"

"You didn't ask me what I wanted to do."

"Well, I'm asking now. Do you want a different one?"

"You always do this."

It slipped out. It had a hard shape, like a stone.

"I always do what?" said Mateo, bewildered.

"You always take over! You always decide for everybody. You did it with the sleepover and you did it with the game last month and you did it with the group chat and now you're doing it with this, and then you say it's a joke if anybody gets mad!"

A silence landed on their four desks. Across the room, a couple of kids looked over.

"I'm not taking over," Mateo said. His voice cracked. "I'm trying to make a plan. Somebody has to."

"Can you both stop," said Josie quickly. "Everyone is looking."

"I don't care who's looking!" said Wren, and her voice was higher than she'd ever heard it. "Forget it. Do it without me.

You were going to anyway."

She stood up so fast her chair tipped over. It hit the floor with a bang.

Mrs. Okafor said "Wren?" in the careful voice teachers use when they don't want to be a part of the problem but know they are.

"I need a minute," said Wren, which was the only sentence she could still find, and she walked out the door with her ears on fire.

• • •

The library was empty except for Ms. Park, the librarian, who was putting stickers on the spines of new books. She glanced up as Wren came in, took one look at her face, and said, "The reading corner is free. Take as long as you need," and went back to her stickers. She did not ask a single question.

Wren sank into a beanbag in the corner, her face hot and her hands trembling. Her heart was pounding so hard she could hear it in her ears. *Mateo is a bully*, said her brain. *He thinks I'm nothing. He didn't even ask. Everyone's looking at me. I embarrassed myself.* Then, a half-second later: *I'm a horrible person. I yelled at him. Everyone hates me.*

It was so fast and so loud. It was like standing in a room with all the radios on at once.

Static, she thought, suddenly. *This is what Theo means.*

She looked at her hands. She could almost see Grumble floating over her head, gray and fuming, and Fuzz prickling on her shoulder, and Mumble in the shadows, wanting to run away. Not a real thing. But a good name for a real feeling.

What does it want? she asked herself, as if Theo were asking. Slowly, her breathing came up from the floor of her chest. She pressed her palms against her knees. *To be heard.*

Okay. Heard about what?

She made herself stop and breathe the way Mom had taught them, in for four, out for six, with the out-breath longer than the in. She did it five times. The pounding in her ears went from a drum to a tap. Her thoughts, which had been tumbling, slowed enough to be looked at one at a time.

She looked at the first thought. *Mateo is a bully.*

Was he? A bully, she knew, is someone who hurts people on purpose, over and over, and keeps going when you ask them to stop. She thought about Mateo. Mateo, who had once handed her his own umbrella in the rain and walked home soaked. Mateo, who made a plan for everything because plans made him feel safe. Mateo, whose knee bounced when he was scared. When he took over, did he stop if someone said stop? She actually did not know, because she had never said it. She had yelled it, after months of letting it pile up, with a "you always" on the front.

Was it true he *always* did it? She tried to remember an example besides the sleepover. She found two. That was not

always. That was twice, and a feeling.

She looked at the second thought. *He thinks I'm nothing.* Nobody had said that. Mateo had given her a small job because it was the last one left. He had probably not thought about it. Which was its own kind of thing, but a different kind of thing.

What she could actually say about it was this: *When you gave out the jobs without asking, I felt like I didn't count.* That was true. It was also about as different from "You always take over!" as a sentence could be. One of them was a complaint, and the other one was something a person could answer.

She sat there for another minute.

"Wren?"

She looked up. It was Josie, standing awkwardly at the end of the shelf. Josie, who had once cried at a commercial for a bank.

"Mrs. Okafor said I could check on you," Josie said. "Mateo is in the hall. He feels terrible. He said to tell you he's sorry and he's not going to talk unless you want him to. And Imani said, um, to say she's here if you want." She shifted. "I don't know why I said all that in one breath."

Wren laughed, a wobbly laugh. "Thanks."

"Are you okay?"

Fine, Wren almost said. She heard it coming and stopped it with her teeth.

"No," she said. "I'm kind of a mess. I need a few more minutes, and then I think I owe Mateo a real sentence."

"Okay," said Josie. She stood there, not sure whether to stay or go. Then she sat down in the other beanbag, a little way off, and took a book off the shelf and opened it upside down, which Wren did not mention.

Ms. Park went on putting stickers on the spines.

After a while the bell rang. Wren went to wash her face. The hall was full of kids and noise, and it was just a hall. She was not fixed, not by a long shot. But the radios had been turned down, and she could finally hear what she was going to have to do.

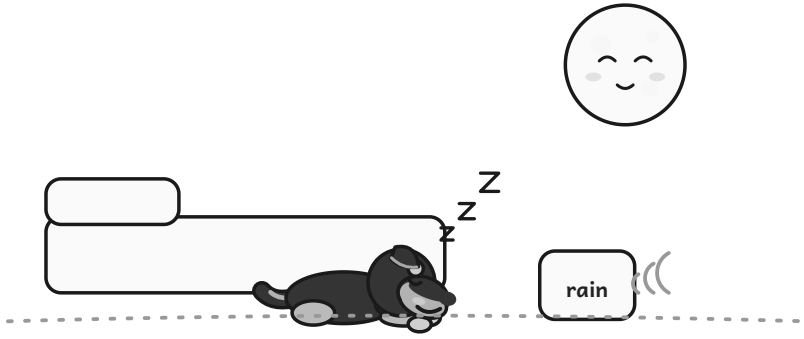


Try this

- When the static comes, name the feeling and ask what it wants. "Grumble wants to be heard" is a start.
- Your thoughts when you're upset are guesses, even when they feel like facts. Pick one and ask: Did they say that, or did I?
- Try swapping "You always…" for "When you did this, I felt that, and I'd like this." The first is a verdict. The second is something a person can answer.

CHAPTER 6

Lights Out



Theo's room had rules, and Wren had agreed to every one of them. She had even helped write them.

One. Lights out at 8:30. Two. The rain sound stays on all night. Three. Screens go in the hall drawer at 8:00. Four. If you need to talk after lights out, you whisper, and you only whisper about something that can't wait.

They had written these on a poster over her new bed, in two colors of marker, on the Sunday before. It had seemed so reasonable then. Sharing a room had seemed like a thing you could manage with a poster.

That was before the Friday of the project.

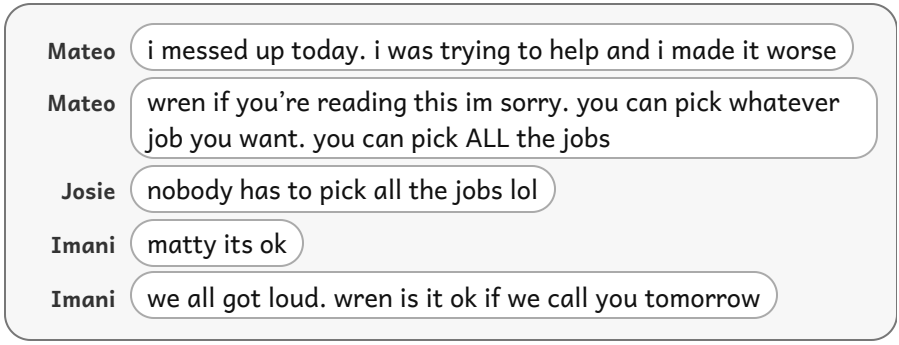
By eight o'clock that night, Wren was empty. She'd had a few crackers for dinner. Her stomach was too knotted for food, and her body was too tired for anything else. She'd managed one short sentence to Mateo in the hallway: *I'm sorry I yelled. Can we talk Monday?* He'd nodded fast and said "Yeah. Totally. Yes," and looked at his shoes. It was something, but it wasn't enough. It sat in her chest like a stone she hadn't finished swallowing.

At 8:00, she was supposed to put her phone in the hall drawer.

She didn't.

She told herself it was just to check the time. She told herself she'd be quick. She got into bed, pulled the blanket up, tilted the screen so the light stayed in the cave of her knees, and opened the chat.

It had come back to life all afternoon.



Her eyes burned. There was a lump in her throat the size of a walnut. She had wanted so badly for them to say this. And now they had, and all she could think was that she'd been

unfair, and everybody had seen it, and maybe they'd say it was okay only because they felt sorry for her.

They're being nice because they pity me, she thought, and her chest tightened.

"Wren," said Theo, from his bed.

"One minute," she whispered.

She started to type a reply. She deleted it. She started again. The screen flashed, and her phone buzzed against the mattress, and the buzz came through the whole bed like a small earthquake.

"Wren."

"One minute, Theo."

It was 8:19. In the dark, Theo's bed gave a small creak as he sat up. He had his headphones around his neck, and she could just make him out, sitting straight, with his hands folded in his lap.

"It's eight nineteen," he said. "The phone was supposed to go in the drawer at eight. The light is blue. It is shining on the ceiling. And it buzzes. The rain sound can't cover it."

"I know. I'm sorry. I just have to answer something important."

"Okay," said Theo.

He lay back down.

She typed. *hey. i'm sorry about today. i was having a really*

Buzz. Josie had sent a heart.

Buzz. Mateo, a sad face with a tear.

Buzz. Imani: *so can we call tmrw??*

Each one made a little pulse of blue on the ceiling. Wren watched her own hands tremble. Under the covers it was too hot, but she didn't want to move. *Just one more. I just have to say the right thing.* She did not know what the right thing was, and the harder she looked for it, the more it slid away.

From across the room, Theo spoke again. His voice was higher.

"It's eight thirty-four."

"Theo, please. I'm trying."

"Lights out was eight thirty. It's eight thirty-four. The phone is still on. The rule says eight." He was breathing fast now. "I can't go to sleep with it on. I have to go to sleep at eight thirty. If I don't, tomorrow is wrong. And it's still buzzing."

"I KNOW," said Wren, much louder than she meant to. "Just give me a second!"

Silence.

Then, in a very small voice: "It's been fifteen minutes of seconds."

And there it was. Something in her went off like a firecracker. The heat that had been building since Monday,

since the kitchen, since the pancakes, all of it rose up in one huge, hot wave. She couldn't hold it in. She did not even try.

"You are SO annoying!" she said, sitting bolt upright. "Do you know that? Everything has to be your way! Your rules! Your times! Your headphones! You make everybody else's life harder, and then you act like you're the one who's suffering! No wonder nobody gets you! No wonder the dogs are the only ones who want to be around you!"

She heard what she had said when it was already out. It echoed in the room, like a plate that has been dropped and hasn't yet landed.

Nobody moved. The rain sound pattered on, soft and steady.

Then Theo did something Wren would never forget. He did not yell. He did not cry. He took his headphones from around his neck, put them over his ears, rolled over to face the wall, and lay perfectly still.

The silence of it was the loudest thing she had ever heard.

"Theo," she whispered.

Nothing.

"Theo, I didn't..."

He didn't move. His back was a small, stiff shape under the blanket, and Tidbit, who had been asleep on the rug, got up and padded over and lay down against his bed, pressed along the side of it, like a guard.

Wren's phone buzzed again. She turned it face down, then off, and shoved it into the drawer of the nightstand with shaking hands. The room went dark. The only light left was the little glow of the clock: 8:41.

She sat there for a long time with her arms around her knees.

That was not fine, she thought. *That was not even close to fine.*

She knew exactly what she had done. It was not a feeling or a guess. She had said something cruel, on purpose, to the person who was least able to fight back, and it had worked: his whole face had gone shut. Her stomach turned over.

There was an excuse, of course. She'd been tired, and hungry, and stretched thin. All of that was true. But she was already learning that being tired explains a thing without making it okay. An excuse could tell you why it happened. It couldn't take it back.

She wanted to say sorry. Right then. She had her mouth open to say it, and the words *I'm sorry* got stuck somewhere behind her teeth, heavy and flat as pennies.

If I say it now, he'll have to listen to me, and he's got his headphones on, she thought. *He doesn't want me talking.* She didn't know if that was a guess or a fact. She wanted to know, but she was afraid of the answer.

So she lay down in the dark, under a ceiling with no star, and listened to the rain. It sounded like a tiny sky, weeping

politely to itself. After a long time, her eyes closed.

Down the hall, in the room that had once been hers, Grandpa Lou was awake. He heard the shouting. He heard the quiet that came after. He lay there, thinking, with his hands folded on his chest, and he did not go in.

Because he knew something Wren was about to find out. The worst moment of the night was over. The most important moment was still to come, and it was going to be on the stairs.

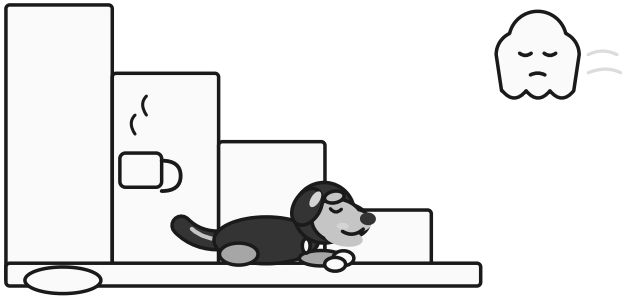


Try this

- Phones and screens have a way of making the rest of the world seem small. If a shared room or a shared house has a screen rule, keep it. It's kind, and it's also a promise.
- If you say something cruel when you are worn out, you still said it. Being tired explains it. Saying sorry is how you fix it.
- When the words won't come, it usually means your body isn't ready yet. Give yourself a short break, and make a plan to return.

CHAPTER 7

The Stairs



Wren woke up at 11:40 with her heart already running.

For a few seconds she didn't know why. The room was dark. The rain sound pattered. Across from her, Theo was a small shape under the blanket, turned to the wall. Then everything came back at once, in the order it had happened, and her stomach dropped through the mattress.

You are SO annoying.

She put both hands over her face.

She tried lying still. She tried counting, which didn't work. She tried the breath, in four, out six, and managed three rounds before her thoughts got loud again. After a

while she gave up, slid out of bed, and padded into the hall in her socks.

There was a strip of yellow light under the stairs.

Grandpa Lou was sitting on the third step from the bottom in his bread-loaf slippers and a bathrobe that had once been blue, with a mug of something steaming, and Sugarfoot stretched out across the step below like a furry draft stopper. He looked up as she came down. He didn't seem surprised.

"Weather's fine for a walk," he said. "A little breezy, with a chance of regret."

"You heard," said Wren.

"The whole house heard." He patted the step beside him. "Sit. It's a good step. It's got a view of the front door."

She sat. Sugarfoot lifted her chin off the stair, looked at Wren with serious eyes, and put it back down, close enough that Wren could feel her warmth against her ankle. Neither of them said anything for a bit. It was the kind of quiet that doesn't ask for anything. Wren found she could breathe in it.

"I said something terrible," she said at last.

"I know."

"I said nobody gets him. I said the dogs are the only ones who want to be around him." Her voice wobbled. "That isn't true. It isn't even a little true. And I knew it was the worst thing I could say. I said it anyway."

Grandpa Lou nodded slowly. He didn't tell her it wasn't so bad. She was grateful for that.

"Did it come out of nowhere?" he asked.

"No. I was so tired. And everything's been loud. And I'm mad about my room, and I'm mad at Mateo, and I'm mad at myself, and the phone kept buzzing and he kept saying the rule and I just..." She made a small explosion with her hands. "I wasn't even mad at him. He was the one who was there."

"That happens," said Grandpa Lou. "The mad goes looking for an address, and it doesn't always find the right one."

Wren stared at him. It was nearly word for word what she'd thought on the first day.

"That's a very good explanation, Grandpa."

"I stole it from your brother. He said it at dinner." He smiled a little. "Listen, Wren. What happened up there isn't something you can make fine. You can't make it disappear. But it's also not the end of the road. Do you know what Theo's doing right now?"

"Hating me?"

"I'd be surprised. Let's guess it's something else. Something about his body. When a person has gotten too loud inside, or heard something that hurt a lot, some people get louder. And some people go quiet. Their body puts on a brake. They aren't punishing anyone. Think of a circuit breaker. If it didn't trip, the house might burn down."

"So he's not ignoring me on purpose?"

"I can't say for certain. I wasn't in his head. But I know your brother. When Theo goes quiet, he's usually not trying to hurt you. He's trying to hold on to himself."

Wren thought about this. "But what if it is on purpose? What if he doesn't want to talk to me ever again?"

"Then you would live with that, and you would still have apologized. But I don't think so." He took a sip. "Here's how you can tell the difference between a kid taking a break and a person freezing you out. A break has a way back. Somebody says what's happening ('I need some time,' or just a face that closes up) and comes back, sooner or later, when they're ready. Freezing someone out is different. It goes on and on and nobody says why or when it's going to end, and the point of it is to make you feel bad for as long as possible."

"Theo doesn't do that."

"No. He told you he was taking a minute under a table, remember? He tells people. That's the whole reason his rule works." Grandpa Lou looked into his mug. "Most of the time the person who needs a break isn't the problem. The trouble starts when nobody knows when they're coming back."

Wren plucked at her sleeve. "You said that like you know."

"I do." He was quiet for a moment. "I had a brother named Ray. We were ten and twelve, and we shared a room, believe it or not. A lot like this one. He was always whistling, and I was trying to read, and one night I said something awful. I

said, 'You're a baby and no one likes you.' It was a lie, and the instant it left my mouth I wanted to catch it and put it back."

"What did Ray do?"

"Went quiet. For a week." He shook his head. "I didn't say sorry for four days. Do you know why? I was embarrassed. And I thought if I said sorry too soon, he'd laugh. And I thought if I said it too late, it wouldn't count. So I waited, and the waiting got harder, and I started telling myself he was being silly to be mad. A great trick, by the way. I recommend nobody try it."

"What happened?"

"On the fifth day I walked into the kitchen and said the three things." He held up fingers. "One: *I'm sorry.* Two: *I told you something cruel, and it wasn't true, and it was my fault.* Three: *What can I do to make it right?* And Ray looked at me for a very long time, and he said, 'You can stop calling me a baby.' And I said, 'Done.'"

"That's it?"

"That's it. It was the best-tasting sandwich I ever ate, because we ate it together." He smiled. "Ray's eighty-one now. He still whistles."

Wren laughed. It was a small, wet laugh, and then the tears came. She put her face on her knees. Grandpa Lou did not say anything. He moved a little closer, and put one big, warm hand on her back, very lightly, and left it there.

Sugarfoot let out a long sigh and pressed her whole side against Wren's feet.

It felt like the first kind thing that had happened all day.

"Did I make him hate me?" she said, into her knees.

"I don't know," said Grandpa Lou honestly. "That's up to him. What I do know is this. You can't force a person to forgive you on your schedule. You don't get to say sorry and then demand that it's all better by breakfast. What you can do is make an honest apology and then give it room to land. That is what makes an apology an apology, and keeps it from turning into an order."

Wren wiped her nose on her sleeve. "What if he says no? What if he needs a long time?"

"Then you wait, and you keep being the kind of person someone could forgive. You'd be surprised how much of the repair is just that."

"But how do I even start?"

"A few things." He counted again. "First, don't do it right now. It's midnight, he's asleep, and the rule is eight-thirty. Tomorrow, ask him when would be a good time. Let him pick. Second, say what you actually did. Not 'I'm sorry if you felt bad.' That one's useless. Say 'I said you were annoying and that nobody gets you, and it wasn't true, and it hurt you.' Third, don't explain it away. I know you were tired. You can tell him that if he asks, but save it for after."

"An excuse explains," said Wren slowly. "An apology fixes."

“Where did you get that?”

“I just thought of it.”

“That’s good. Write it down.” He raised his mug at her. “And fourth, ask what would help. Don’t guess. He’s got a better handle on his needs than most adults.”

She nodded. A weight she hadn’t known she was carrying shifted a little. She was still sorry. She still felt sick. But there was a path now, small and narrow, and it ran from where she was to where she needed to be.

They sat there for a while longer. Grandpa Lou finished his tea. Somewhere in the house, the barometer clicked softly. Out the front window, a car went by, and its headlights slid across the ceiling and were gone.

“Grandpa?”

“Mm.”

“Thank you for not coming in.”

“I thought about it.” He chuckled quietly. “Then I thought, she’s old enough to get here on her own. And look. Here you are.”

She leaned her head against his shoulder. He smelled like peppermint and sawdust.

“Up to bed,” he said, a few minutes later. “Tomorrow’s got a forecast to it.”

“What kind?”

"I'd say partly sorry, with a good chance of sandwiches."

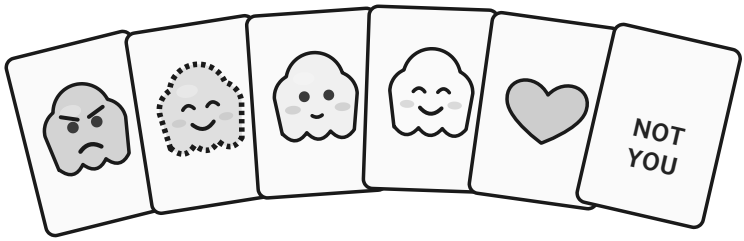


Try this

- A pause works best when it has a name and a time. "I need twenty minutes. I'll come back at eight." Without the time, a pause can feel like a door slamming.
- Going quiet can have different reasons. Sometimes it's a person freezing someone out to make them hurt. Often it's a body putting on a brake. Ask, don't guess: "Are you taking a break?"
- Make an apology out of three things. Say sorry. Say exactly what you did. Ask what would help. Then give it room.

CHAPTER 8

Three Things



Saturday was the longest day of Wren's life.

She woke at 6:00 exactly, because that was when Theo's alarm went off, a soft chime like a very polite bell. Theo got up, dressed, made his bed with square corners, and left the room without looking at her. Not rudely. The way a person leaves a room when the room has a thing in it that is too big to look at.

Wren lay there under the missing star for ten minutes. Then she got up, went downstairs, and waited by the kitchen until he was done with his cereal.

"Theo?"

"Yes." He did not look up.

"I want to say something to you about last night. It's a sorry. I'll say it whenever you want, wherever you want. When's a good time?"

Theo set down his spoon. He sat very still for several seconds, and she could see him turning the question over, the way he did with questions that were really about time.

"Not now," he said. "I need the morning. I'll be better after the show."

"The four-thirty show?"

"Yes. Four-thirty to five. Then I feed the dogs at 5:30. Then I will be ready at 5:35."

"Five thirty-five," said Wren. It was nine hours and thirty-five minutes away. It felt like nine years. "Okay. I'll be there. Thank you for telling me a time."

Theo looked at her for the first time. His eyes were serious, a little wary. "You said thank you for the time," he said.

"Because a time is better than a no."

He nodded. Then he went back to his cereal, and Wren walked out of the kitchen with her heart doing something complicated.

It would have been very easy, all that day, to talk herself out of it. She could have decided it wasn't such a big deal. She could have told herself he'd forgotten. She could have followed him around, apologizing in small, anxious bursts that would have been all about her own guilt and none of it

about him. She did not do any of those things. She cleaned the bathroom. She did the dishes. She took the dogs out and picked up after them. Whenever she felt a rush of *I have to fix this now*, she took a breath and thought: *It's not time yet. He asked for a time. I'm giving it to him.*

It was not easy. But it was something. She was learning that waiting could be a way of caring.

At 11:30, the group chat buzzed. She looked. It was Imani.

Imani hey. are you free to call this afternoon? no pressure

Wren i'd like that. can it be 7:30? i have to do something first

Imani yes of course. 7:30 works

Wren read it twice. *Yes of course.* Two small words that didn't ask her to explain. She put the phone down and felt a muscle she hadn't known was tight let go a little.

At four-thirty, the living room filled with the sound of the Frequency Buddies theme song. Theo sat in his usual spot on the rug, an exact two feet from the television, with his stuffed Tidbit in his lap. Wren stayed in the kitchen doorway, where he could see her, and did not come in.

At five, the show ended. At 5:30, Theo fed the dogs. He put a small card on the bag. At 5:35 exactly, he walked up to Wren in the hallway and said, "Ready."

They went to the porch. It was getting dark and the air smelled like leaves. They sat on the top step, with Sugarfoot

between them and Tidbit lying on the lawn, her chin on her paws, watching with enormous interest.

Wren had practiced. She'd practiced in the shower, and in the bathroom mirror, and in her head during the dishes. She opened her mouth, and her practiced words flew off like startled birds. So she just said what was true.

"Theo. I'm sorry."

He waited.

"Last night I said you were annoying, and that nobody gets you, and that the dogs are the only ones who want to be around you. None of that is true. It was a mean thing to say, and I said it because I was mad about other stuff, and you were right there. That was not okay. It was my fault. I said it to hurt you, and it did."

Theo's hands were in his lap. He was looking at a spot on the porch rail.

"What would help?" Wren said. "What can I do to make it right?"

For a long time, there was only the sound of crickets, and Sugarfoot's slow breathing.

"I don't know yet," Theo said finally. "Can I think about it?"

"Yes. You can have as long as you need."

"Okay." He rubbed his thumb along his knee, back and forth. "I'm going to say some things. They might be in the wrong order."

"That's fine."

"First." He held up one finger. "You said nobody gets me. I get me. I know exactly what I am. I'm somebody who likes rules and clouds and hears the refrigerator from upstairs. I'm not broken. I'm just built differently."

"I know. I'm sorry."

"I know you know. I'm saying it so it's said." He held up two fingers. "Second. I said, 'It's been fifteen minutes of seconds.' I think that was rude, and I didn't mean it to be. I couldn't find another way to say what was happening. The truth was that I was getting very loud inside, and I should have said that. I should have said, 'I'm getting loud inside. I need the light off.' That would have been better."

"I think that's a good sentence," said Wren. "I'll remember it. And I should have put the phone in the drawer. It was in the rules. I wrote half of them."

"You did write half," Theo said, with something that was almost a smile.

"Third?"

"Third." He held up three fingers. His voice was careful. "When you are mad at something else, it feels like the mad is coming at me. I can't always tell. So can you tell me when it's not about me? You can just say, 'I'm mad, and it's not you.' Then I can stop checking."

Wren's throat hurt. "That's a really good thing to ask for."

"I thought so." He put his hand down. "Mom says that asking for what you need is part of the job."

"I can do that. Every time."

"Okay." He was quiet. "I also think you were very tired. But that's not a reason. Grandpa says an excuse explains and an apology fixes."

"I told him that."

"I know. He told me." Theo looked at her, for the second time that day, and then, for about one second, right in the eyes. "Apology accepted. Mostly. It's maybe eighty percent. I'll let you know when it gets to a hundred."

It was the most generous number Wren had ever been given.

She did not hug him. She wanted to, very much. Instead, she said, "Would you like me to move over, or would you like me to stay close?"

Theo thought. "Stay," he said. "But a little over. Tidbit gets the middle."

So she scooted over, and Tidbit scrambled up and wedged herself into the gap between them, and the three of them sat there in the dusk, with Sugarfoot on the far side, a long row of two kids and two dogs on a step. Wren put her hand on Tidbit's back. After a minute, Theo put his hand next to hers. Not on it. Beside it. That was exactly right.

• • •

Later, they made the cards.

It was Theo's idea. They sat on the floor of the room with markers and a stack of index cards. Wren drew the pictures and Theo wrote the words. By nine o'clock, they had a deck of eight. There were three that matched the ladder: a green card (*CALM AND CONNECTED*), an orange card (*REVVED UP*), and a gray one (*RUNNING ON EMPTY*). There was a card that said *I NEED A MINUTE. BACK AT _____*. There was one that said *NOT ABOUT YOU*, with a little drawing of Grumble holding up both hands. There was *ROOM, PLEASE* and *STAY CLOSE, PLEASE*. And a last one, Wren's idea, in purple: *CAN YOU HEAR ME OUT BEFORE YOU HELP?*

"That's the card for me," she said.

Theo studied it. "I thought it was. You like to say everything first, and then somebody fixes it."

"How did you know?"

"You do it with the dogs." He shrugged. "You tell Sugarfoot your whole day. She never says anything. You always come out looking better."

It took Wren a moment to find her voice. "I think that might be the nicest thing anyone's said to me this week."

"It was just an observation," Theo said.

They hung the cards on a ring by the door. Then Wren went to the poster on the wall, took out a marker, and under the rules in neat letters she added: *Five. Screens go in the drawer at 8:00. That includes Wren.* After a moment she

added a sixth. *Six. If you are loud inside, say so. Whoever is closer to the door opens it.*

Theo read it twice. "Okay," he said. His shoulders dropped, though he did not smile, and he went to brush his teeth, humming the Frequency Buddies theme.

At 7:15, her phone buzzed. It was Imani. *Ready when you are. No rush.*

Wren looked at the cards on their ring by the door, and at the rules on the wall, and at her brother, who was lining up his toothbrush with the edge of the sink.

"Okay," she said, to nobody in particular. "My turn."

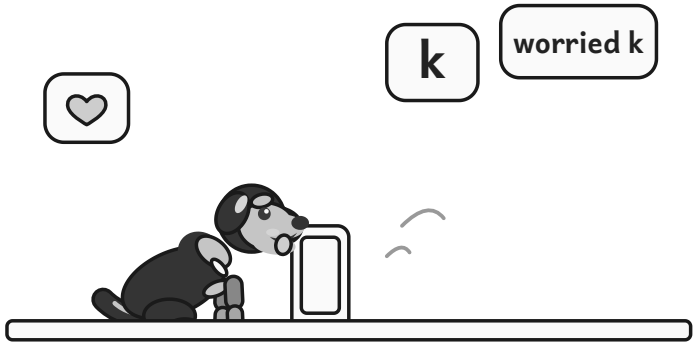


Try this

- Ask for a time instead of a yes or no. "When would be a good time?" lets the other person say when they'll be ready.
- Say what you did, in plain words, without "if." "I said you were annoying" is clear. "I'm sorry if you felt bad" is not.
- When someone is hurt, the apology is the start. They can take as long as they need. Staying kind while you wait is part of it.

CHAPTER 9

Read It Again



Wren took the call on the back steps, with Sugarfoot beside her and her breath making small clouds in the cold.

She had practiced this one too. She had written a list on the back of her hand in pen: *1. Say I'm sorry for going quiet. 2. Ask about the K. 3. Listen.* The ink had smudged a bit, but the numbers were still there.

Imani picked up on the first ring.

"Hi," said Imani.

"Hi."

There was a pause, the awkward kind. Wren could hear a television somewhere on Imani's end, and a pot clanking, and someone laughing, which had to be Imani's nana.

"I'm sorry I went quiet," Wren said, before she could lose her nerve. "And I'm sorry I muted the chat. And that I said 'fine' like a hundred times. I wasn't fine. Things at home got really loud, and I didn't know how to say so, and I took it out on everyone."

"Thank you," said Imani. Her voice relaxed. "I was kind of scared you hated me."

"I didn't. I thought you hated me."

"What? Why?"

Wren took a breath. This was number two.

"Because of the K."

"The what?"

"Your 'k.' On Monday, when I said my grandpa was moving in. I told you something really hard, and you wrote 'k.' Just one letter. It felt like..." She searched for the word. "Like closing a door."

There was a long silence on the line.

"Oh," said Imani. "Oh, Wren. No."

"No?"

"I was at the bus stop. It was freezing. I had these huge mittens on, and I was typing with one thumb and holding my backpack in the other arm, and the bus was coming." She was talking fast. "I'd just read your message and I thought, *oh no, she's sad, I should call her.* But I couldn't

because the bus was there, and I wanted to say 'okay, I'm here, we'll talk later.' And all I had time for was a k."

Wren stared at the dog. "That's... not what it looked like at all."

"I know that now. I never thought about how it would look." Imani sounded stunned. "It wasn't even a short k. It was a *worried* k."

"A worried k," said Wren, and the first laugh she'd had all week came out.

"I should have sent more. I could have said 'I'm worried about you.' I knew I'd be thinking it, but you couldn't see that."

"No, it's not your fault. I read it in a mean voice. I heard it as cold. If somebody had asked me, 'Wren, how do you hear a one-letter message?' I would have said it sounded like a slap."

"Because you were upset."

"Because I was upset," said Wren. "And tired, and hungry, and I thought all the worst things before I could think any other thing."

"That happens to me too. Like, constantly." Imani's voice went soft. "You know what my nana says? She says a message only has half the meaning in it. The other half is in the person reading it."

"Your nana is a genius."

“She’s very modest about it.” A pause, and then Imani said, more carefully: “Wren? When you said ‘fine’ so many times, it did sound like fine, so I didn’t know. If you’d said ‘I’m not okay and I don’t want to talk about it,’ I’d have said, ‘Okay, I’m here.’ I would have been completely fine with that.”

Wren sat with that for a moment. It was a very simple idea, and it had not crossed her mind.

“I think that’s what I should have said,” she said slowly. “I didn’t know that was allowed.”

“It’s allowed.”

“I’ll say it next time. ‘I’m not okay and I don’t want to talk about it yet.’”

“And I’ll write back a real sentence,” said Imani. “Not a k. I promise. Or if I’m in a hurry, I’ll write ‘k, worried, will call.’”

Wren laughed again, harder this time, with the cold air on her teeth. “A worried k. I’m going to put that on a shirt.”

• • •

“So,” said Imani. “Mateo wants to talk to you. He’s here. He was too scared to call. Is that okay? Or do you want to wait?”

Wren thought about it. She was a little tired, but not empty. Her body was a green rung, or close to it: heart slow, ears normal, mind at about half-speed.

“I’m okay,” she said. “Put him on.”

There was rustling. A cough. Then Mateo's voice, uncharacteristically small.

"Hey."

"Hey."

"I'm sorry," said Mateo, all at once, like a dam breaking. "I'm so sorry about the project. I was trying to get a plan together and I just assigned everybody a job without asking. I do that when I'm nervous. I get scared we won't finish and I start deciding stuff really fast so I don't have to feel the scary part. It isn't fair to everybody else. Also I'm sorry about the alarm clock thing."

Wren's stomach tightened, then loosened. "Can I tell you about the alarm clock thing?"

"Please."

"I know you didn't mean it mean. I'm pretty sure you were trying to cheer me up. But my brother isn't a joke to me. He's kind of the person I'm closest to, even when it's hard. When you said that, it sounded like his way of being is funny. And I was already feeling like..." She stopped, then pushed on. "Like it was all kind of a joke and nobody was taking it seriously."

There was a long quiet.

"I didn't think about it that way," Mateo said. "I make jokes when somebody's sad. Not because I think it's funny. Because I don't know what to say, and the quiet makes me nervous. It's... I think it's my version of a k."

"A worried joke," said Imani, in the background.

"Yes. Exactly. A worried joke." He let out a breath. "I'm really sorry. Theo seems cool. I'd never make fun of him on purpose. I mean it."

"Thank you," said Wren. "I believe you."

She realized, with some surprise, that she did. She hadn't just decided to say it. It was true.

"Can I say something about the project too?" she said. "It wasn't just that you didn't ask. I think I'd been holding it for a while. The sleepover, and the game, and a couple of other times, when you decided and I just kind of went along. I never said anything. I let it build up. Then it came out as 'you always take over,' which wasn't fair, because it wasn't always. It was a few times. I should have told you the first time."

"I'd have wanted you to," said Mateo. "I really would. I'm not trying to boss anybody. If somebody says 'hey, can you ask first,' I can. It's easy. It's just that nobody did, and I didn't notice."

"So. Can you ask before you assign?"

"Yes. And can you tell me right away when I'm doing it, instead of waiting until you're so mad you're going to flip a chair?"

"I did not flip the chair."

"It was a tip," said Josie, who had apparently been there the whole time. "More of a controlled tip."

Everybody laughed at that, even Wren. It felt like warm water poured over cold hands.

"Okay," said Imani. "Let's make some rules. Because I think we need them."

They did it right there, on the call, with Wren writing on the back of her other hand. It took about ten minutes. Josie, who had mostly been quiet, said she wanted one too: when people got loud, she froze up, and she needed someone to say her name gently and wait. They wrote that one down first.

By the time they were done, the list was long and a little silly. It said:

The seven rules

1. If a message could be read two ways, ask "did you mean it like that?"
2. If it's long or hard, call. Don't type.
3. "Fine" is allowed. After "fine," someone asks "fine, or need a minute?"
4. "Not about you" is a real sentence. Use it.
5. Nobody makes jokes about anybody's family. Family is not a bit.
6. If you're nervous, say you're nervous. Worried jokes and worried k's are okay if you say they're worried.
7. Ask before you assign.

Wren read it back aloud. It sounded absurd and true.

"I love it," said Josie. "Can we make it a poster?"

"No," said Mateo. "Yes. Actually, yes."

When the call ended, Wren sat for a minute on the steps in the dark. Sugarfoot, who had listened to the whole thing with her head on her paws, looked up at her with an expression of mild approval.

"Yes, I know," Wren told her. "A worried k."

Sugarfoot thumped her tail twice on the step. Then she stood up, shook herself, and padded back into the warm house.

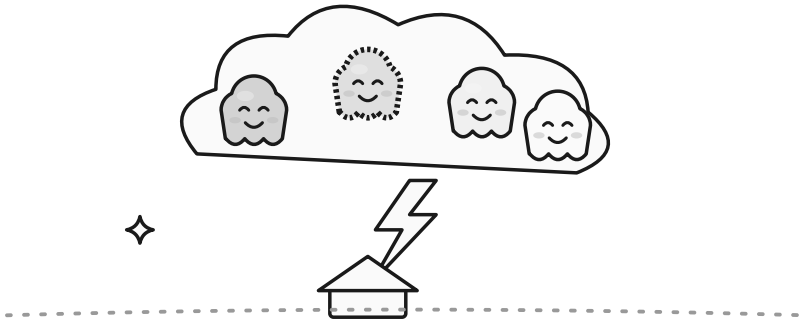


Try this

- A short message leaves out the face and the voice. If it stings, you can ask: "Did you mean it like that?" Most of the time, the answer is no.
- If you are not okay, you can say so, even if you can't say why. "I'm not okay and I don't want to talk about it yet" is a whole sentence.
- Some people take over when they are nervous, and some people joke. You can say what you see without calling the person a name: "When you decide fast, I feel left out. Can you ask first?"

CHAPTER 10

One Owner Per Job



On Monday, the four of them met at lunch with a roll of tape, a stack of paper, and Mateo's notebook, which he handed to Wren before anyone had said a word.

"I thought you should hold it," he said. "That way you can see if I start assigning stuff."

"You are going to be unbearable about this," said Josie.

"I'm trying to be good!"

"You're being good," Wren said, trying not to laugh. "Okay. Let's do this right. Everybody tell us what they'd like to do. Then we'll see where there's overlap."

"What's overlap?" asked Josie.

"When two people want the same thing."

It turned out there was very little. Mateo, who loved building, wanted the model. He said so, and he said it as a request: "Can I be the model person? I have the clay." Imani, who drew everything, wanted the poster. Josie wanted to write the talk, and she wanted a backup, because she got nervous when she had to give the talk alone. Wren, to her own surprise, wanted none of the above.

"I want the part about why thunderstorms happen," she said. "The science part. Like, how it works. And I want to show how it's like static."

"Like the clouds on Theo's show?" said Imani.

"Kind of. Thunderclouds build up electric charge. It's called static. And lightning is how the cloud lets it go." Wren had read that in a library book, in a beanbag, on Friday, and it had stuck in her mind like a burr. "When the charge builds, you get a storm. When it discharges, it's over. The sky clears. It doesn't last."

"That's actually kind of beautiful," said Mateo.

"Don't tell my brother. He'll want it on a card."

They wrote it all down. Each job had an owner and a backup, in two columns, just like at Wren's kitchen table. Imani wrote the column headings: *Who does it. Who steps in.* Mateo was the model, with Josie as backup. Imani was the poster, with Wren as backup. Josie was the talk, with Imani as backup, and Wren was the science, with Mateo

behind her. They taped the sheet inside Mateo's notebook, and Mateo sat back with a look of enormous satisfaction.

"Look at that," he said. "Everybody has a job. Nobody has a little job."

"There are no little jobs," said Josie solemnly. "Only little clouds."

• • •

It was not a perfect week.

On Wednesday, Mateo's model collapsed, clay and all, in the middle of the cafeteria, and for a second Wren saw his face start to go the way it had on Friday: fast words, bouncing knee, a plan forming. She could see him reaching for his notebook, to reassign everything.

"Mateo," she said.

He looked up.

"Fine or need a minute?" she asked.

He stared at her. Then, slowly, he sat back down. "Minute," he said. "I need a minute. I'm nervous."

"Okay. Take it. We'll pick up the clay."

They picked up the clay. It took four minutes, and Mateo hummed under his breath the whole time, and when he was done, his shoulders had come down from his ears. "Okay," he said. "I'm back. The model is fine. I think I can make it a better volcano. Which is not what we're doing. A better thunderstorm."

“Go for it,” said Josie.

On Thursday, Josie froze.

They were practicing the talk in the library, and when she got to the part about lightning, her voice went thin. She stopped. Her face was pink and her eyes were wide.

Wren knew that look. She had seen it in the mirror.

“Josie,” she said quietly. That was all. She said it the way they’d agreed, gently, and then she waited. She did not say “You’re doing great!” or “Just breathe!” or any of the other things people said that hit the ears like gravel.

Josie swallowed. “I know it,” she whispered. “I know every word. It just all went away.”

“That’s allowed. It’s your body hitting the brakes. It’ll come back.”

“Okay.” She breathed. “Okay. Can somebody say the first line?”

“I’ll do the first line,” Imani said, as backup, and she did. And then Josie said the second, and the third, and the whole thing came back, line after line, like a train rolling out of a tunnel.

They had done it. It wasn’t dramatic. Nobody cheered. But Wren felt it settle in her, like a dropped stitch found and picked up: that was what a team was.

• • •

On Friday, they stood in front of the class.

Mrs. Okafor had seated herself at the back with her clipboard and her reading glasses, looking terrifyingly interested. The model sat on the desk: a handsome clay thundercloud, painted in two shades of gray, with a little flash of yellow lightning in the middle and a tiny paper house underneath, as if daring it.

Josie gave the talk. Her hands shook, and her voice only wavered once. Imani held up the poster at the right moments, a beautiful diagram with arrows and a cross-section of a cloud. Mateo stood behind the model and kept his hands to himself, which Wren knew was costing him a lot.

Then it was Wren's turn.

"So, how does a thunderstorm work?" she said. "Imagine a cloud getting more and more full of static. It builds and builds. It's loud, and it's tense, and it feels like it'll never end."

She paused. She had not planned the next part. It came on its own.

"But then the charge finds a way to let go. That's lightning. It's very loud and very bright, and it's over in a flash. And then the air is clear. It rains. A storm is the sky doing what it has to do so it can feel better."

She saw Imani's face go soft. She saw Josie smile. She saw Mateo look at his model with a new expression, as if someone had finally said what he'd been trying to build.

"Thank you," she finished. "That's our project."

There was a short silence. Then Mrs. Okafor stood up and took off her glasses.

"Do you know what impressed me most?" she said. "The science was good. The model was good. But what I noticed was that each of you knew exactly what your job was, and each of you knew who was behind you. That's rarer than good clay." She nodded. "Well done. All four."

At their desks afterward, Mateo whispered, "Did she say we were rarer than good clay?"

"I think so."

"That's going on the poster."

"What poster?"

"Our other poster. The rules poster." He grinned. "We're making it a thing."

• • •

That afternoon, when Wren got home, Grandpa Lou was at the kitchen table with his reading glasses on and a pencil behind each ear, working on the fix-it list. Tidbit was asleep on his feet.

"Well?" he said.

"We got an A."

"I knew it. I could tell by the forecast."

"There wasn't a forecast."

"There's always a forecast. It's just written in the way people walk in." He put down his pencil. "Come here. Look at this."

On the whiteboard, under *Who does it* and *Who steps in*, there was a new row at the bottom, in Mom's handwriting. It said: *Noticing, remembering, planning.* In the first column, it said *Wren.* In the second, *Everybody.* And under that, in Theo's careful capitals: *WITH A CARD.*

"Your mother added it this morning," said Grandpa Lou. "Said she wanted to say thank you for the pile."

Wren stared at the board. Then she stuffed her hands in her pockets and looked at the floor, because her eyes were suddenly doing something undignified.

"Mom's going to cry again," she said.

"I think she already has," said Grandpa Lou. "It's been a week of weather."



Try this

- A good team job list has two columns: who does it, and who steps in. Everybody has a job and everybody has a backup.
- Ask before you assign. Say what you want to do as a request: "Can I be the model person?"
- If someone is frozen, say their name gently and wait. You don't have to fix it. A backup can say the first line.

CHAPTER 11

Weather Report



Grandpa Lou found his apartment in the second week of December.

He announced it at Sunday breakfast, standing at the head of the table with a plate of pancakes held aloft like a trophy. "Ground floor," he said. "Three blocks from the park. Two windows, one radiator that sounds like a sea lion, and a landlord who owns a barometer. I signed the lease on Friday. I move in on the fifteenth of January."

For a second, nobody said anything.

Then Theo said, very clearly: "That's a number."

"It is a number," agreed Grandpa Lou. "I thought you'd like that."

"I do." Theo sat up straighter. "It's thirty-three days. I counted."

"You can't have counted that fast," said Dad.

"I started counting on Tuesday. When he said he was looking."

Mom laughed, and wiped her eyes with a napkin, and said, "Oh, Lou." Dad got up and hugged his father around the shoulders, which almost knocked over the pancakes. Tidbit jumped up to see what the excitement was. Sugarfoot lay across the doorway, where she had lain every morning for ten weeks, and sighed in a way that sounded a lot like *finally, some news.*

Wren sat very still.

She noticed it right away: a swirl of feelings, all at once, like three radios playing different songs. Gladness, because Grandpa Lou had found a place he liked and his knee wouldn't have to climb anything. Relief, because it meant she'd have her room back. And under that, something she had not expected: a small, aching pang, like a tooth when you bite down on the wrong side.

I'm going to miss him, she thought. *And I'm going to miss the rain sound.* That second one was a surprise.

She felt her ears go warm. Not hot, just warm. She paid attention. Her heart was a little faster than it should be. That was orange, or nearly. She took a breath, in for four,

out for six, and found she could think around the edges of it.

"I'm having a lot of feelings," she said.

The whole table looked at her.

"It's not about anybody," she added. "It's just, I'm happy for you, Grandpa. And I'm also kind of sad. And glad. All of them. At once."

"That sounds right," Grandpa Lou said gently. "Mixed weather. Very common this time of year."

"Do you want room, or do you want me close?" Theo asked her, using the voice of a person who had been waiting ten weeks to ask the question the other way.

Wren stared at him. Then she laughed, and her chest unknotted.

"Close," she said. "Please."

Theo got up, walked around the table, and stood next to her chair. He did not hug her. He put one hand flat on the back of her chair, the way you might put your hand near a dog you did not want to startle. It was the kindest thing she had seen all week. Tidbit squirmed under the chair and shoved her face into Wren's knee.

• • •

They had all learned a lot in ten weeks.

The ladder on the fridge was crowded with magnets now, and nobody's was always on green. Dad's was often orange

on Mondays. Mom's, since the permission slip, spent more time on green than it had in years. Grandpa Lou's lived mostly on a rung of its own, which he'd drawn in himself with a pencil: *CHEERFULLY CONFUSED.* Theo's moved around, but he moved it himself, and he told people why. Wren's magnet had been on gray twice and orange five times since October, but she had put it there each time without being asked. That was the difference. She noticed, and she said.

The group chat had a pinned message now, at the top, with all seven rules, and a drawing underneath of a round peach-colored friend and a squishy purple square friend sharing one heart. Imani had drawn it. She said she'd copied it off a logo and changed the faces.

Mateo had invited everybody to the roller rink, and Josie had invited everybody to the same roller rink on the same day, and neither of them had checked with the other, which Imani said was the most Four Corners thing that had ever happened.

The Friday sleepover had never been canceled. It had only been moved, three times, to when everybody was ready. Now it was the second Saturday of every month, and Imani's nana made peach cobbler, and nobody was ever left alone with a muted phone.

On Wren's first night back in her old room, she lay in her bed under the crooked glow-in-the-dark star, in the quiet, and found that she could not sleep.

It was too quiet.

There was no rain sound. No tiny creak of Theo's bed. No small breaths. She lay there for ten minutes, staring at the ceiling, hearing the house tick, and she thought, *This is what I wanted. This is my room. I have my door.* And she did. And it was fine. And it was also, in some small way, not.

She picked up her phone. It was 8:12, which meant technically it was already in the wrong place. She took it to the hall drawer and put it in. Then she stood, in the dark hallway, and looked at the closed door of Theo's room.

Rough day, she had typed to the group chat earlier. *Not about you. Need an hour.* And Imani had written back: *k (worried k, but also fine k). want cobbler after?* And Wren had laughed so hard she'd had to sit down on the stairs.

She raised her hand to Theo's door. Then she knocked. Three times. And waited.

"It's Wren," she said.

"I know," said Theo, from inside. "You always knock three times now."

"I learned it from somebody."

There was a pause. Then the door opened a few inches, and Theo stood there in his rocket pajamas, with his headphones around his neck and his glasses on crooked. Behind him, the room was exactly as it should be: the little row of stuffed Frequency Buddies on the shelf, in order of height, with the ducklings last. The soft rain sound was

pattering. The nightlight was shaped like the Moon. And there was Tidbit, curled in a circle on the rug, who lifted her head and thumped her tail.

"I couldn't sleep," Wren said. "It's too quiet."

"I know," said Theo. "I thought you might say that."

He held out a small, round, white machine, with a cord trailing from it. It was exactly like the one by his bed.

"I have two," he said. "I got the second one in October. I was waiting to see if you'd want it."

Wren took it. It was warm in her hand. She turned it over. On the bottom, in tiny, careful capitals, was written: *FOR WREN. IT IS RAIN.*

She did not trust her voice for a second.

"Thank you," she said. "You didn't have to."

"I know," said Theo. "I wanted to. It's a thing you do when you notice."

"Okay." She laughed softly. "Okay. Goodnight, Theo."

"Goodnight." He paused. "It's 8:20. You're two minutes late to bed. I'm not mad. I'm just saying the number."

"Noted," said Wren.

She went back to her room and plugged in the machine and pressed the button. The soft pattering of rain filled the dark. Above her, the old star glowed green and faint and a little crooked, and below it the barometer on her wall,

which Grandpa Lou had left behind on purpose with a note that said *FOR THE WEATHER GIRL*, clicked once in its sleep.

Outside, it had started to rain for real.

She listened to both rains at once, the one on the machine and the one on the roof. They did not quite match. Somehow it did not matter. She let the sound wash over her, the way you do when you are on the green rung and the radios are off and the house is full of people you love.

Forecast, she thought, drifting. *Partly cloudy. A chance of static. Everyone accounted for.*

Then she slept.



Try this

- Mixed feelings are normal. You can be glad and sad at the same time. Name both, and say if they are about anybody: "It's not about you. I have a lot of feelings."
- Notice what someone needs before they ask. A small thing done on purpose, like a second rain machine, is a way of saying you pay attention.
- Tonight, check the ladder. Calm and connected, revved up, or running on empty? No answer is wrong. It is just the weather. You can ask what would help.

Words to keep

Three things for an apology

1. Say sorry.
2. Say exactly what you did, in plain words.
3. Ask what would help. Then give it room.

A pause with a name and a time

"I need twenty minutes. I'll come back at eight." Without the time, a pause can feel like a door slamming.

Sentences from this book

- "I need a minute."
- "Fine, or need a minute?"
- "I'm mad, and it's not about you."
- "Did you mean it like that?"
- "Do you want room, or do you want me close?"
- "Can I be the model person?"

For grown-ups

This story follows one eleven-year-old through a crowded few months: a room that stops being hers, a group chat that goes wrong, a project that goes sideways, and a sentence she wishes she could take back. Each chapter ends with a short box of things to try.

The ideas underneath come from the free site at spreadloveandacceptance.com. The ladder (calm and connected, revved up, running on empty) is a simple way to notice where the body is. A message has only half its meaning in the words. A job has the doing and the noticing. A pause needs a time to come back. An apology is three things, and the other person sets the pace. Theo and Wren are wired differently, and each one has to learn the other's language. Neither is wrong.

Some questions to talk about together: Where was each character on the ladder in the group chat chapter? What did "k" mean to Imani, and what did it mean to Wren? Which job on your own list is invisible? What would a green card, an orange card and a gray card say in your house?

About this book

Wren, Theo and their family are made up, and so are their friends. Nobody in this book is a real person, and none of it is a testimonial.

Tidbit, Sugarfoot, Professor Puddles and the clouds of Static live at spreadloveandacceptance.com, where they star in the Frequency

Buddies cartoon. Everything on the site is free to read and use.

The words in this book were drafted with an AI writing tool. The pictures were drawn by code, written with an AI tool, in the same style as the site's characters.

Free to read online at spreadloveandacceptance.com